



Word Meaning and Sound Devices

Grade 7 • North Carolina • Reading

RL.7.4

Determine word meaning using context clues in prose and analyze how rhyme and repetition of sounds affect meaning and tone in a poem. An 80-minute block-period packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner discussion, independent practice, small-group work, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the 80-minute block

Level and alignment

Grade 7 · North Carolina · Reading; RL.7.4 — Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in a text; analyze the impact of rhymes and repetitions of sounds on meaning and tone.

What is included

Cover; teacher guide; vocabulary and lesson preview; original passage; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group intervention and enrichment (4 items); exit ticket; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (80 minutes)

Warm-up 8 min · passage + guided practice 25 min · partner discussion 12 min · independent practice 20 min · small-group work 10 min · exit ticket 5 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key. Review the passage and organizer before class. No outside novel or paid app required.

Student directions

Read the passage carefully. Use evidence from the text to support every answer. Quote or closely paraphrase the text and name the paragraph.



Before you read

Key vocabulary

Lesson focus

Context clues are nearby words or sentences that hint at an unfamiliar word's meaning. In poetry, rhyme and repeated sounds (alliteration, assonance) are not just decoration — they can slow a reader down, create a mood, or emphasize an idea. Read a poem aloud, even silently, to notice its sound.

Model 1 — "The tide receded, leaving the sand pocked with shallow pools." What does "receded" likely mean, and what clue helped?

Moved back or retreated — the clue is "leaving the sand" exposed, which only makes sense if the water pulled away.

Model 2 — In "the wind whipped and whistled," what sound device is used, and what mood does it create?

Alliteration (repeated w sound) and it creates a harsh, restless, unsettled mood matching the wind's force.



WARM-UP

Warm-up · Before you read

Answer using what you already know. Five minutes.

1. What does "moorings" most likely mean, based on the first paragraph's context?

2. What context clue helps define "moorings"?



After the Storm (prose excerpt)

The harbor the morning after looked like it had aged ten years overnight. Boats that had strained at their moorings now sat crookedly, their hulls scraped raw where they had knocked against the dock. Gulls picked through debris with a kind of businesslike indifference, as if this happened every week.

Old Mr. Petrides stood at the end of the pier, surveying the wreckage of his bait shop's awning, torn clean from its posts. He did not look angry. He looked, instead, resigned, the way a person looks at a bill they already knew was coming.

"Could've been worse," he said to no one, and began, methodically, to coil a length of rope that had washed loose in the night.



Harbor, After

The wind whipped and whistled, wild and wide,
It battered the boats where they bobbed and cried.
The gulls, unbothered, glided and grinned,
While ropes lay tangled, twisted, and thinned.

The old man stood where the pier met the sea,
Still as the water was choosing to be.
He counted his losses in murmurs, not moans,
A harbor rebuilding itself, stone by stone.



Guided practice · Evidence organizer

Work through this organizer together before independent practice.

It Says

Quote or closely paraphrase the text.

It Means

Explain the evidence in your own words.

And So

State the inference or analysis it supports.

1. What does "indifference" mean as used to describe the gulls?

2. What context clue supports that meaning of "indifference"?

3. What does "resigned" mean as it describes Mr. Petrides?

4. Why does the author compare Mr. Petrides's expression to someone looking at an expected bill?

Partner discussion

Discuss each question with a partner before writing a joint response.

1. Identify one example of alliteration in the poem's first stanza.

2. How does the alliteration in "whipped and whistled, wild and wide" affect the poem's tone?

3. Find one rhyme pair in the second stanza and explain what feeling it helps create.

Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

1. How does the poem's tone shift between the first and second stanzas?

2. What does "unbothered" mean in "The gulls, unbothered, glided and grinned"? Use context.

3. Why might the poet choose the word "grinned" to describe the gulls, even though gulls cannot literally grin?



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

4. What does "rebuilding itself, stone by stone" suggest about the harbor's recovery?

5. How does the repeated -st sound in "still," "stone by stone" affect the poem's ending?

6. Compare the mood created by sound devices in stanza 1 to the mood of the prose excerpt's first paragraph.



Small-group work

Use with students who need additional support.

1. What word in the poem means the same as "resigned" from the prose excerpt, based on context?

2. Explain how repetition of the "o" sound in "moans... stone by stone" contributes to tone.

Small-group work

Use with students ready for additional challenge.

1. Why is "counted his losses in murmurs, not moans" an effective description of the old man's reaction?

2. Using both texts, explain how word choice and sound work together to build the same overall impression of the old man.



Exit ticket

Answer independently to show what you learned today.

1. Choose one word from either text whose precise meaning changes how you understand a sentence, and explain using context.



Exit ticket · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this with my teacher.



Answer key

1. The ropes, chains, or fixed points that hold a boat in place — the boats "strained at their moorings," suggesting something restraining them.
2. "Boats that had strained at their moorings now sat crookedly" — the strain implies something was holding them, and the crooked result after the storm confirms it.
3. A lack of concern or interest — the gulls are described as picking through debris in a "businesslike" way, suggesting they are unaffected emotionally.
4. The phrase "as if this happened every week" suggests the gulls are unbothered by the destruction, matching a definition of not caring.
5. Accepting something unwanted without resistance — the text compares his look to someone facing "a bill they already knew was coming," which is a resigned, expected acceptance.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. It shows he is not surprised or overwhelmed by the storm's damage, just quietly accepting it as something he anticipated.
7. "whipped and whistled, wild and wide" or "bobbed and cried" — repeated initial sounds across nearby words.
8. It creates a harsh, forceful sound that mimics the storm's intensity, reinforcing a tone of chaos or violence.
9. "sea/be" or "moans/stones" — the steady rhyme creates a calmer, more controlled feeling that contrasts with the storm's chaos, matching the old man's quiet acceptance.
10. The first stanza's harsh sounds create a chaotic, violent tone describing the storm; the second stanza's steadier, quieter sounds shift the tone to calm acceptance, focused on the old man.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. Not troubled or affected — this matches the prose description of the gulls' "businesslike indifference," showing both texts describe the same lack of concern.
12. It personifies the gulls, suggesting an almost mocking or careless attitude toward the destruction, similar to the "indifference" described in the prose.
13. That recovery will be slow and steady, happening in small, deliberate steps rather than all at once.
14. It creates a slow, steady rhythm that reinforces the idea of gradual, patient rebuilding, matching the calm tone of the final lines.
15. Both are chaotic and unsettled — the prose describes crooked, scraped boats and indifferent gulls, while the poem's harsh alliteration ("whipped and whistled") creates a similarly turbulent mood.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. "Still" — "Still as the water was choosing to be" suggests calm acceptance, matching the prose's description of Mr. Petrides as resigned.

17. The repeated long "o" sound slows the reading pace, creating a mournful but steady tone that matches quiet acceptance rather than despair.

18. It shows restraint — murmurs are quiet and controlled, while moans would suggest louder distress, matching his resigned, undramatic response in the prose.

19. Both texts show him as calm and accepting rather than devastated; the prose's "resigned" description and the poem's steady rhymes and soft sounds ("still," "stone by stone") reinforce this same controlled, quiet response to loss.

20. Answers vary; require a specific word, a context clue used to define it, and an explanation of how that meaning shapes understanding of the sentence or passage.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

AIG

Ask for a second interpretation, a counterexample, or a student-written item at the same rigor, with an explanation of the choice.

504

Follow the individual plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

EC

Pre-teach key vocabulary before reading. Model the first guided-practice item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

ESL

Preview key vocabulary with examples. Allow brief home-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence starters for open-response items.

Official alignment source • accessed September 18, 2026

RL.7.4 — Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in a text; analyze the impact of rhymes and repetitions of sounds on meaning and tone.. The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the standard.

NC ELA Standard Course of Study, Grade 7: <https://www.dpi.nc.gov/documents/publications/catalog/>

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